

# PSCI 3350.001 Comparative Politics

Lecture 2: Democracy, democratization, and comparative history

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# Today's puzzle

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Why did some states enter the twentieth century with durable democratic institutions while others remained authoritarian or experienced democratic breakdown?

Two readings give us different parts of an answer:

- **Ishiyama** offers a historical explanation across six countries
- **Lijphart** shows how to evaluate comparisons when cases are few and causes are many

# Learning goals

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By the end of class, you should be able to:

- 1. Distinguish a democratic **threshold** from degrees of **polyarchy**
- 2. Explain Ishiyama's three historical conditions for democratization
- 3. Compare the six country trajectories using common questions
- 4. Diagnose the “many variables, small number of cases” problem
- 5. Turn a historical narrative into a testable comparative claim

# Opening comparison

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## Britain

- Parliament constrained the Crown before industrialization
- Landed elites became commercially oriented
- Political inclusion widened gradually

## Russia

- Autocracy remained dominant
- Serfdom and elite dependence persisted
- Reform arrived late and was reversed

Cold-call question: Which difference looks most causally important, and what evidence would change your mind?

# Part I: The outcome to explain

# Democracy has more than one definition

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## Schumpeter

Democracy is a method for selecting leaders through a **competitive struggle for votes**.

This is a narrow, procedural definition.

The definition determines which cases count as democratic.

## Held

Democracy requires **political equality** among members of the political community.

This is a more demanding standard.

# Dahl's polyarchy

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Dahl treats democracy as an ideal and uses **polyarchy** for real political systems.

## Competition

- Elected officials
- Free and fair elections
- Freedom of expression
- Alternative information
- Independent associations

## Participation

- Broad suffrage
- Broad eligibility for office
- Equal consideration of preferences

Countries may improve on one dimension without improving equally on the other.

# A democratic threshold

For the study of transitions, Ishiyama uses four minimum components drawn from Linz and Stepan and from Rose, Mishler, and Haerpfer.

| Component               | Diagnostic question                                |
|-------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|
| Rule of law             | Are rulers bound by law?                           |
| Civil society           | Can groups organize independently of the state?    |
| Free and fair elections | Is there meaningful competition for office?        |
| Accountability          | Must governing officials answer for their actions? |

No single component is sufficient. The combination identifies whether a regime has crossed a democratic threshold.

# Two measures answer different questions

| Concept           | What it measures                         | Best question                     |
|-------------------|------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Minimal democracy | A categorical threshold                  | Has the regime become democratic? |
| Polyarchy         | Degrees of competition and participation | How democratic is the regime?     |

Democratization first establishes the minimum institutions, then can deepen competition and participation.

# Part 2: Ishiyama's historical argument

# Industrialization as a political shock

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Industrialization changes more than production.

- New classes seek political influence
- Cities and markets unsettle older hierarchies
- States face demands for representation and protection
- Existing institutions must absorb or repress conflict

Ishiyama treats industrialization as a storm. The outcome depends partly on the political vessel constructed before the storm arrived.

# Sequence is the central mechanism

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## Before

National identity, social order, and limits on rulers develop unevenly.

## During

Industrialization creates new wealth, classes, conflicts, and demands.

## After

Institutions incorporate new groups, break down, or harden into authoritarian rule.

The same economic shock can therefore produce different political outcomes.

# Three historical conditions

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- 1. **Political national identity** existed before industrialization
- 2. **Accountability and rule of law** constrained rulers before industrialization
- 3. The **feudal or old social order** had been transformed before industrialization

The argument is configurational. The conditions reinforce each other rather than operating as isolated causes.

# Political national identity

Ishiyama distinguishes cultural community from political unity.

| Concept      | Basis of membership                                                |
|--------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Kulturnation | Shared language, culture, religion, or ancestry                    |
| Staatsnation | Shared political institutions and a recognized political community |

Cultural homogeneity does not automatically produce political integration. Japan was relatively homogeneous, yet its modern political identity had to be constructed.

# Accountability before mass politics

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The issue is not whether a country already had universal suffrage.

The issue is whether institutions had already established that:

- Rulers could be constrained
- Revenue and law required bargaining
- Organized interests could act outside the state
- Political conflict could occur within accepted institutions

Early accountability provided channels through which later demands could enter politics.

# Transformation of the old order

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A landed elite may respond to economic change in different ways.

## Transformed elite

- Wealth becomes commercial
- Status depends less on hereditary privilege
- Elites can bargain within representative institutions

## Persistent old order

- Land and labor remain coercively organized
- Elites depend on autocratic protection
- New groups threaten established privilege

The second path makes democratic inclusion more threatening to incumbent elites.

# The argument as a causal chain

| Stage            | Historical question                           | Expected consequence                        |
|------------------|-----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| Community        | Is there an accepted political nation?        | Conflict stays within a shared polity       |
| Constraint       | Are rulers accountable under law?             | New demands enter established channels      |
| Social order     | Has hereditary privilege been transformed?    | Elites can tolerate broader participation   |
| Industrial shock | How intense is social disruption?             | Earlier arrangements face a stress test     |
| Outcome          | Are conflict and inclusion institutionalized? | Democracy, instability, or authoritarianism |

# Part 3: Six trajectories

# Britain

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- Political centralization and national integration developed early
- The wool economy and enclosure weakened the traditional peasantry
- Landed elites became commercially oriented
- Parliament defeated royal absolutism and secured rule-bound bargaining
- Suffrage expanded within an already accepted institutional arena

Democratization widened access to the stadium. It did not require constructing a new stadium during the crisis.

# France

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- Absolutism subordinated nobles and weakened independent accountability
- Labor-intensive agriculture preserved a large peasantry
- The Revolution destroyed noble privilege but did not produce immediate institutional consensus
- New social demands repeatedly met resistance outside stable channels
- Democratic development lurched through revolution, reaction, and constitutional redesign

France shows partial preparation followed by repeated institutional rupture.

# United States

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- Colonial assemblies established traditions of representation and accountability
- The country lacked European feudalism
- A unified political nation remained contested by sectional identity
- Slavery sustained hereditary racial privilege in the South
- Civil War settled the supremacy of the national state through violence

Institutions arrived early, but national political integration arrived late.

# Germany

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- Political fragmentation persisted into the nineteenth century
- The Junker elite retained power in Prussia
- Unification occurred through authoritarian state-building and war
- Industrialization outpaced democratization
- Weimar inherited deep cleavages, weak democratic commitment, war debt, and severe crisis

Rapid state formation did not produce an equally rapid democratic settlement.

# Japan

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- Tokugawa rule ended civil conflict but preserved decentralized feudal structures
- Meiji leaders constructed political identity around loyalty to the emperor
- The state directed modernization under external pressure
- Old domains and military traditions were adapted rather than fully displaced
- Durable democracy followed defeat and postwar institutional reconstruction

Japan separates cultural homogeneity from democratic political integration.

# Russia

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- Empire preceded a distinct modern national political community
- Loyalty centered on the Tsar and the state
- Autocracy destroyed or subordinated alternative centers of power
- Serfdom and a dependent nobility persisted
- Reform after 1905 left the Tsar's veto and dissolution powers intact
- War and state collapse opened the path to revolution rather than democracy

Russia is Ishiyama's sharpest contrast with Britain across all three historical conditions.

# Six cases on common dimensions

| Case          | Political identity before industrialization | Accountability before industrialization | Transformation of old order | Broad trajectory                             |
|---------------|---------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|-----------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| Britain       | Strong                                      | Strong                                  | Extensive                   | Gradual inclusion                            |
| France        | Partial                                     | Weak                                    | Partial                     | Repeated rupture                             |
| United States | Contested                                   | Strong                                  | Mixed because of slavery    | Integration through civil war                |
| Germany       | Weak                                        | Weak                                    | Uneven                      | Authoritarian unification, fragile democracy |
| Japan         | Constructed from above                      | Weak                                    | Partial                     | State-led modernization, postwar democracy   |
| Russia        | Imperial loyalty                            | Very weak                               | Minimal                     | Autocracy, revolution                        |

# Paired contrast: Britain and France

Both countries experienced commercial change, state formation, and class conflict.

| Similar background             | Critical difference                                                                     |
|--------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Early European states          | Parliament constrained the English Crown, while French absolutism prevailed             |
| Powerful landed elites         | English elites commercialized more fully, while French landlords retained peasant labor |
| Industrial and urban pressures | Britain incorporated groups gradually, while France repeatedly rebuilt institutions     |

This pairing directs attention to accountability and elite transformation.

# Paired contrast: United States and Germany

Both were late projects of national political integration with strong regional divisions.

| United States                                                        | Germany                                                            |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Representative institutions preceded full national integration       | Authoritarian unification preceded national democratic integration |
| No European feudal order, but slavery preserved hereditary privilege | Junker privilege persisted within the new state                    |
| Civil war consolidated national authority                            | External war consolidated an authoritarian empire                  |

Similar problems of unity were processed through different institutions.

# Paired contrast: Japan and Russia

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Both pursued state-led modernization under autocratic authority.

- Political identity centered on personal loyalty to the sovereign
- Bureaucratic states promoted rapid economic and military change
- Older social and military hierarchies persisted
- Independent civil society and accountable institutions remained weak

The comparison suggests that modernization alone does not generate democracy.

# Part 4: Lijphart's design audit

# Four ways to study politics

| Method       | Cases                 | Control strategy                                          |
|--------------|-----------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Experimental | Designed observations | Random assignment or direct manipulation                  |
| Statistical  | Many                  | Estimate relationships while controlling for alternatives |
| Comparative  | Few                   | Select and compare cases to approximate control           |
| Case study   | One                   | Generate, probe, confirm, or challenge theoretical claims |

For Lijphart, the comparative method follows the same logic of control as statistical analysis, but with too few cases for conventional statistical control.

# The central comparative problem

Many plausible explanatory variables, but only a small number of cases.

In Ishiyama's cases, democratic outcomes may reflect several factors at once.

- National identity
- Accountability
- Agrarian class structure
- Timing of industrialization
- War and defeat
- Religion
- State capacity
- International intervention

If several causes change together, a comparison cannot easily isolate one effect.

# Lijphart's four responses

| Response                | Practical move                                    |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Increase cases          | Add countries, regions, or historical periods     |
| Reduce property space   | Combine related categories and variables          |
| Select comparable cases | Hold background conditions as similar as possible |
| Focus on key variables  | Prefer a parsimonious explanation                 |

Each response improves leverage, but each also creates tradeoffs.

# How Ishiyama addresses small N

| Lijphart's response     | Ishiyama's design                                   |
|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| Increase cases          | Uses six national histories rather than one         |
| Reduce property space   | Organizes diverse histories around three conditions |
| Select comparable cases | Builds paired contrasts with partly shared contexts |
| Focus on key variables  | Emphasizes sequence before industrialization        |

The chapter gains clarity by simplifying history. That same simplification creates questions about omitted causes and scope.

# Comparable means comparable for a question

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Cases do not need to be identical.

They need to be similar on factors treated as controls and different on the factor believed to matter.

## Stronger pairing

Britain and France for early state development, agrarian change, and constraints on rulers.

## Harder pairing

Britain and Japan when geography, external pressure, timing, and institutional inheritance all differ.

Comparability is produced by the research question and the design.

# Case studies can serve different purposes

| Type                  | Role in theory                                          |
|-----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| Atheoretical          | Describes a case without engaging a broader proposition |
| Interpretive          | Uses an existing theory to explain a case               |
| Hypothesis-generating | Develops a new proposition from close study             |
| Theory-confirming     | Adds a case that fits an existing proposition           |
| Theory-infirming      | Adds a case that weakens confidence in a proposition    |
| Deviant               | Studies an unexpected case to refine the theory         |

Hypothesis-generating and deviant cases are especially useful for building better explanations.

# Deviant cases refine probabilistic claims

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Suppose the claim is:

Early accountability usually increases the chance of durable democratization.

A case with early accountability and democratic failure matters, but it does not automatically disprove the claim.

Questions for the deviant case:

- Was accountability genuine or only formal?
- Did war or state collapse overwhelm the expected effect?
- Does the theory require another condition?
- Is the claim limited to a particular historical scope?

# A design audit of the chapter

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## Explanatory gains

- Common questions discipline six narratives
- Historical sequence identifies plausible mechanisms
- Paired contrasts reveal meaningful differences
- Cases connect institutions to social structure

## Remaining limits

- Cases are concentrated in major powers
- Several causes move together
- Outcome categories are broad
- The framework is strongly rooted in Western history

The comparison is valuable when its scope and uncertainty remain explicit.

# Part 5: From reading to research

# A claim-evidence map

| Element                 | Example                                                                                               |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Claim                   | Early constraints on rulers make later democratic inclusion more durable.                             |
| Mechanism               | New groups can pursue demands through accepted institutions rather than extra-institutional conflict. |
| Evidence for            | Britain had parliamentary constraint before industrialization and expanded participation gradually.   |
| Comparative evidence    | France developed under absolutism and repeatedly experienced rupture during inclusion.                |
| Rival explanation       | Different agrarian class structures, not accountability, drove the contrast.                          |
| Discriminating evidence | Compare cases with similar agrarian structures but different levels of early accountability.          |
| Scope                   | European states undergoing early industrialization.                                                   |

# Team comparison workshop

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For the focal country and shadow comparator:

- 1. Record each country's value on Ishiyama's three historical conditions
- 2. Identify one outcome that differs between the countries
- 3. State one causal claim that could explain the difference
- 4. Name one rival explanation
- 5. Identify evidence that would distinguish the two explanations

The goal is not to find two identical countries. The goal is to make the basis of comparison explicit.

# A stronger team presentation

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An effective weekly presentation includes:

- One comparative puzzle
- One explicit causal claim
- Evidence from both countries
- One rival explanation
- One limitation of the comparison
- One question for the class

The presenters defend the comparison. The class serves as the design review panel.

# History constrains without determining

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Ishiyama rejects a mechanical reading of the argument.

- Long-term structures shape the options available to leaders
- Critical moments still involve political choices
- Institutions can redirect inherited conflict
- External shocks can alter trajectories

Historical conditions change probabilities. They do not write an unavoidable political future.

# Core takeaways

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- . Definitions determine the outcome we are trying to explain
- . Ishiyama emphasizes the sequence of identity, accountability, and social transformation before industrialization
- . The six histories become comparable only when organized by common questions
- . Lijphart identifies the central weakness of the design: many causes and few cases
- . Pairing, parsimony, rival explanations, and deviant cases can strengthen comparative inference

# Exit ticket

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Submit three sentences before leaving:

- 1. **Claim:** One historical condition that shaped democratization
- 2. **Evidence:** One comparison from today's six cases
- 3. **Design caution:** One reason the evidence may not isolate the claimed cause

The strongest answer connects Ishiyama's substantive argument to Lijphart's method.